

3 GUIDES IN 1

The Starter Pack

Fix-It Manual • Practice Pack • Global Materials List

Everything a beginner needs beyond the patterns: how to fix mistakes, warm-up exercises, and where to find supplies anywhere in the world.

THE EVENING STITCH™

PART 1 OF 3

The Fix-It Manual

Things will go wrong. That's not failure — it's craft. Here's how to fix every common mistake without starting over.

Thread Problems

Thread keeps tangling

Cause: Thread is too long, or twist is building up in the floss.

Fix: Cut thread to 40 cm max. Every 10–15 stitches, let the needle hang freely and untwist. If using metallic thread, cut to 30 cm and go slower.

Prevention: Pull the floss strand by strand from the skein (never yank a long piece). Run each strand through beeswax once to smooth it.

Thread keeps breaking

Cause: Rough hole edges catching the thread, or metallic thread fraying.

Fix: Widen the hole slightly from the back with your piercer. For metallic thread, use a larger needle to create bigger holes before stitching.

Prevention: Always prick from front to back (the smooth side faces the thread entry point).

Thread won't stay flat

Cause: Using too many strands, or uneven tension.

Fix: Reduce to 2 strands for most work. After each stitch, use your needle to gently arrange the thread flat before pulling the next stitch.

Prevention: Separate strands one at a time from the full 6-strand floss, then recombine the number you need. This removes the factory twist.

Card Problems

Holes tearing or widening

Cause: Card too thin (<200 gsm), or same hole threaded too many times.

Fix: Place a small piece of washi tape on the back over the damaged hole. Re-prick through the tape. The tape reinforces without adding bulk.

Prevention: Use 250 gsm+ card. For complex patterns that cross the same holes, choose thicker stock.

Card buckling or warping

Cause: Thread pulled too tight, especially when many stitches cross the center.

Fix: Place the finished piece face-down on a clean towel. Cover with a damp cloth. Press with a warm iron for 5 seconds. Weight flat under heavy books for 24 hours.

Prevention: Check tension every 10 stitches by turning the card over. If the card is bowing, you're pulling too hard.

Pencil marks won't erase

Cause: Using too soft a pencil (B, 2B), or pressing too hard.

Fix: A soft vinyl eraser (like Staedtler Mars Plastic) removes most marks. For stubborn marks, a kneaded eraser pressed and lifted (not rubbed) works without damaging the card.

Prevention: Use H or 2H pencils with light pressure. Better yet: tape the pattern on top and prick through both layers, so no pencil marks are needed.

Stitching Mistakes

Wrong hole

Fix: Gently pull the thread back through (the hole won't close). Rethread through the correct hole. The wrong hole will be slightly larger — place a tiny dot of white glue (PVA) on the back to tighten it.

Prevention: Mark completed holes on the back with a faint pencil tick as you go.

PART 2 OF 3

The Practice Pack

10 warm-up exercises to build your skills before tackling full patterns. Each takes 5–10 minutes on scrap card.

1

Straight Line

Prick 10 holes in a straight line, 8 mm apart. Running stitch from 1 to 10. Focus on even tension — every stitch should be the same tightness.

Skill trained: Even tension, consistent spacing

2

The Circle

Prick 12 holes in a circle (use a compass or trace a coin). Running stitch around the circle. The curve should be smooth, not angular.

Skill trained: Smooth curves from straight stitches

3

The Fan

Prick 1 hole at the bottom left, 8 holes in a row at the top. Connect the single hole to each top hole in order. This creates a fan shape.

Skill trained: Fan stitch technique, the basis of many patterns

4

Skip Stitch

Prick 20 holes in a circle. Connect hole 1 to hole 5, 2 to 6, 3 to 7... (skip 3 each time). See the star pattern emerge.

Skill trained: Understanding how skip values create different shapes

5 Two-Color Practice

Prick a simple triangle (8 holes per side = 24 holes). Stitch the outline in one color, then fill with a second color in a different stitch style.

Skill trained: Managing multiple threads and color changes

6 The Zigzag

Two parallel rows of 10 holes each. Connect alternating holes between the rows to create a zigzag. Then add a second color weaving through the zigzag.

Skill trained: Herringbone technique, working between rows

7 Tension Test

Prick 5 holes in a row. Stitch with increasing tension: very loose, loose, medium, firm, very firm. Turn the card over and see how each looks from the back.

Skill trained: Learning your ideal tension level

8 The Square

Prick a 6×6 grid of holes (36 total). Stitch horizontal lines in one color, vertical lines in another. Where they cross, the grid pattern emerges.

Skill trained: Grid work and thread layering

9

Speed Round

Print any Beginner pattern from Collection 1. Set a timer for 10 minutes. Prick and stitch as much as you can. Don't worry about perfection — this is about flow.

Skill trained: Building confidence and speed

10

The Signature Piece

Choose your favorite shape from exercises 1-9. Stitch it on good card with your best thread. Sign and date the back. This is your first real piece.

Skill trained: Putting it all together with intention

Global Materials List

Where to find paper embroidery supplies, no matter where you live.

Online — Ships Worldwide

Store	Best For	Notes
Amazon	All basics	Search "paper embroidery kit" or buy components separately. Best for cardstock, thread, and tools.
Etsy	Specialty supplies	Handmade pricking tools, unique card colors, pre-pricked blanks. Support small makers.
DMC official site	Thread	Full color range with searchable color cards. Best thread quality guarantee.
AliExpress	Budget bulk orders	Cardstock packs, basic tools. Quality varies — read reviews. Shipping takes 2–4 weeks.

By Region

North America

Store	Countries	Best For
Michaels	US, Canada	Thread, cardstock, frames. Use coupons (40-50% off single items regularly).
JOANN Fabrics	US	Wide thread selection, craft foam, tools. Student discount available.
Walmart Craft Section	US, Canada	Budget cardstock and thread. Limited selection but cheapest starter option.
Dollar Tree	US	Cardstock packs, basic sewing needles, foam sheets — all \$1.25.

Europe

Store	Countries	Best For
Hobbycraft	UK	Full range. Check the card-making section for cardstock.
The Range	UK	Budget alternative to Hobbycraft. Good for cardstock packs.
Cass Art	UK	Premium card and paper. Best for display-quality pieces.
Action	NL, BE, FR, DE, AT, PL, CZ, IT, ES, LU	Budget craft supplies. Surprisingly good cardstock at low prices.
Søstrene Grene	Nordics, UK, NL, DE, FR, JP	Aesthetic craft supplies. Beautiful card colors.
Tiger / Flying Tiger	Pan-European	Seasonal craft kits, basic supplies at impulse-buy prices.

Australia & New Zealand

Store	Best For
Spotlight	Full range — the go-to craft chain. Thread, card, tools, frames.
Lincraft	Good thread selection and competitive prices.
Officeworks	Cardstock and printing — bring your patterns here for A4 prints.

What to Buy First

The \$25 Starter Kit:

- Cardstock: 50-pack of 250 gsm white or cream (\$6–\$8)
- Thread: DMC or Anchor sampler pack, 36 colors (\$5–\$7)
- Needles: Pack of 6 tapestry needles, size 24–26 (\$2–\$3)
- Piercer: Cork-handled paper piercer (\$3–\$5)
- Foam: Dense craft foam, 10 mm thick (\$2–\$4)
- Tape: Washi tape, any design (\$1–\$2)

That’s enough to complete 30–50 patterns before needing to restock anything.

Your Next Step

Order or pick up the \$25 starter kit this week. While you wait, print your first 3 Beginner patterns from Collection 1 and read the Masterclass Guide.

The Evening Stitch™ — Your Next Step Starts Here